

OUR FUTURE IS DATAISM

IT'S A NEW GLOBAL RELIGION,
AND WE'RE ALREADY PRACTICING IT!

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Humanity's tryst with religion has been an interesting one. We worship and pray to an unseen God through what's written down in scriptures by ordinary humans made of flesh and blood – just like you and me. There's nothing special about a religious priest or any other human authority claiming to represent God or brandish His divine Power of Attorney – which no one can verify. Yet, across the globe, a large portion of humanity chooses to believe in the power of religion. Trusting in blind faith over cold hard facts, following one's heart rather than the mind, all quintessential traits that make us fallible (or is it gullible?) humans.

To borrow a term from *Game of Thrones*, all of us seem so busy worshipping and appeasing the Old Gods – the deities we inherited as a consequence of our birth and years of psychological conditioning – that we've scarcely left any thought for the New Gods (The Seven). If God is supposed to be omnipresent and all-knowing, it can be argued that Data is its most tangible manifestation in this Digital Age of ours circa 21st century. For Data is both everything and nothing, it is seen and unseen, creator and destructor of the world. If the Vishnu Purana were to be rewritten now by a tech-savvy,

digital monk (instead of a hermit sage meditating in the woods many moons ago), pretty certain the tenth reincarnation of Lord Vishnu scheduled to appear in the future would have been Data – and not Kalki. Just like Kalki promises to rid humanity of all evil and usher in a new age of bliss and universal bliss, so does Data hold the potential to help us conquer our innermost demons, unlock the hitherto unseen human potential and guide our civilization to greater heights.

Data is truly magical. To use an analogy from the Star Wars Universe, if we are all Jedis then data is the midi-chlorian in all of us directly influencing our ability to control and master the mystical Force. Data is omnipresent, and without Data there can be no way to master the Force. With it we are powerful and invincible; without it we are vulnerable and certain to diminish.

HOW IS DATAISM ALL-POWERFUL?

An algorithmic order-driven world is on the horizon and it's approaching fast. Through the wonders of machine learning and breakthroughs in artificial intelligence, in the future data is going to dictate our lives unlike any other divine doctrine or man-made religion we've ever known. No longer will we study horoscopes, astrological signs, consult holy books and holy men, if

dataism has its way – and it will. We will live our lives under a different code, one that'll be less forgiving, emotionless, devoid of personal prejudice or bias. A far more analytical life, where decision-making is based completely based on cold hard data alone.

Welcome to post-humanism. If you're wondering what that is, it's nothing but a more dispassionate, more analytical, more logic-driven approach to justify our existence in this world. In post-humanism the malaise of subjectiveness plaguing humanism is severely reduced and the role of the nonhuman agents, especially that of computers and advanced data management / inference systems, is emphasized. Welcome to Dataism. Our new religion. The coolaid from humanity's imminent future.

Think of it as a ground-breaking new way of measuring, seeing, deciding and instructing. A way to live based on highly evolved techniques of analyzing all kinds of data. From browsing histories to shopping patterns, from tracking GPS for location-based services to studying your genomic information to predicting your physiological future and lifespan. And a lot, lot more. Essentially, dataism will usher in a highly customised sense of reality served to you by sensing and gathering unimaginable levels of personal, private and public information to influence your worldview. Powerful software net-